

| 1977 | 10+2+3 SYSTEM OF EDUCATION

The New Class Structure

The goals of the new system like vocationalisation remain partially fulfilled

In 1977, just before the Government instituted the 10+2+3 system, India had four patterns of school leaving exams in operation in India: 10+2+3, 10+2+2+2, 11+3, and 11-12+1+3. A national system was required, one which brought uniformity into the school system, ensured mobility across states, comparability with the rest of the world, and insisted on eight years of elementary school. The idea was born in the Education Commission of 1964-66, headed by former physics professor D. S. Kothari, who went to become chairperson of University Grants Commission, and was assisted by J.P. Naik, the scholar who set up the Indian Council of Social Science Research. But over 30 years later, a lot remains unchanged. Though almost all states have introduced the plus 2 system, in some cases it is administered by colleges, not school boards such as the CBSE. Vocational education after Class 10 is still a distant dream—though a subsequent committee headed by Ishwarbhai Patel recommended that 50 per cent of Class X students be sent to the vocational stream. And there is still little clarity on the three-language formula. The one lasting legacy though is that children receive general education till Class 10, making science compulsory. An INDIA TODAY article said in 1977 that the idea behind the plus two system was to “weed out some students at the end of the first stage of schooling giving such students a certificate. And by adding one more year to school education, the system hopes to improve the standard of university education”. Clearly, it hasn’t happened. As NUEPA’s R. Govinda says three things are a must: “Structural harmony in schools, a national curriculum framework in consultation with states, and a common national database.” What the Union Minister for Education and Social Welfare P.C. Chunder said in 1977—“There is always room for improvement”—is valid even now. Nowhere was it more evident than in the suggestion that school boards could scrap the Class X board exam. What may work for CBSE, which administers the exam, for over 10,000 schools, may not be right for the over 1.5 million schools in the country.

by Kaveree Bamzai

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INDIA STILL DOESN'T HAVE A
UNIFORM SCHOOL SYSTEM

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THE DESAI CABINET AFTER TAKING OATH

THE MAIN EVENT

Morarji Desai becomes Prime Minister

For any party that comes to power—particularly a party that is barely two months old—the establishment of its credibility with the people overrides everything else, and this is true of Janata also. “Where do we go from here?” a newly elected Janata MP was seen murmuring in Vithalbhai Patel House, as he waited for the lift to take him down to Parliament for the swearing-in ceremony. “Don’t be daft,” said his colleague, also new to the Capital, “Haven’t you read the election manifesto? It’s all there in black and white.” “Oh, the manifesto,” sighed the other MP. The first task before the new government is to convince the people—by deeds rather than talk—that it means business. This is not as easy as it sounds. Apart from the Congress for Democracy with which it has formed a joint parliamentary group, there are four distinct blocs in Janata and not all of them see eye to eye on every issue.

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IN 1977, CBSE ADMINISTERED JUST 1,100 SCHOOLS IN INDIA. NOW THE NUMBER IS OVER 10,000.